human remains, the precise relationships of those buried here remain unclear. This represents an entirely novel form of burial in the Harappan realm.

Other Harappan sites display a range of funerary practices. Mohenjo-Daro hasn't revealed a cemetery at all. Harappa, Kalibangan and Rakhigarhi have cemeteries where burials with bodies outnumber cenotaphs, but even taken together, these burials represent only a small fraction of those who must have died.[19] Some scholars have speculated that burials, whether or not with human remains, were given only to members of a certain class and/or ethnicity. What funerary treatment did the rest receive? Cremation is an obvious possibility but archaeological evidence for it is extremely weak (evident only at one small site, Tarkhanwala). Perhaps cremations were held far away from the city, and they didn't collect the ashes to bury in the cenotaphs. Perhaps the dead were consigned to the river or the sea, a practice that has a long history in India (even today certain kinds of people are consigned directly into the Ganga). No one knows for sure. However, at least based on a sample of the exhumed bodies, Harappan life expectancy seems fairly good for that era—'nearly half of the individuals reached their mid-30s and almost one-sixth lived beyond the age of 55'.[20] Many of them had dental caries and likely suffered toothaches.

What did they think about their afterlife? What daily fears and hopes did they harbour? What were their myths, anxieties, humour, repressions, prejudices? Until the Harappan script is deciphered, much of how we answer these questions amounts to informed speculation at best. The script, presumably logo-syllabic, has yielded 400 plus unique symbols (versus 600 plus for Sumerian Cuneiform) on seals, pottery, metal and other artefacts. Parpola feels 'sure that just one language was used in writing the Indus script, because the sign sequences of its inscriptions are repeated throughout' the Harappan realm.[21] Written from right to left, the inscriptions contain only five symbols on average, which some claim make unusually short texts for a linguistic script. Over a hundred claims of decipherment have failed to convince most scholars. Three scholars have even argued that the Harappan symbols don't represent a linguistic script, and may be a system of communication akin to modern traffic signs.[22] This